

But if filmmakers are prisoners of actors' whims, stars are equally vulnerable, literally at the receiving end of the one phone call that will change the course of their monochromatic careers. Sometimes it makes them sign a raft of stale as day-old-samosa movies which are then consigned to the rubbish heap at the box office as happened to Hrithik Roshan after *Kaho Naa... Pyaar Hai* and sometimes it forces them to sit out a year like Shahid Kapoor before Ali gave him the much-needed *Jab We Met*.

Ranbir himself wants to be India's biggest star and greatest actor, but that's in another 10 years. For now, he's content to just be, submerge himself in his latest film, give himself over to the joy of filmmaking, even blurring the line between real and reel. He has, as his closest friend and director of the fine coming-of-age film, *Wake Up Sid*, Mukerji, says, "arrived. But it would be a mistake for him to think that it's more than that." Yes, he is making more money—Rs 7-10 crore per film, and Rs 7.5 crore for each of the six endorsements he has signed. He has just bought himself an Audi R 8 which he intends to drive late at night, listening to music he is discovering for Ali's new film, U2, Elton John, Bob Dylan and Green Day. And he does like the good things of life, from shopping at Prada for house slippers to picking up shirts at James Perse.

But he is completely fearless about his choices and focused on his work. And self driven—after all, in a household where the 15-year-old pug Dudley eats pate for dinner and wears raincoats bought in London, money is not the greatest motivator. "He sits with me for 12 hours on a music recording and comes to scout for locations in Delhi," says Ali. "Ranbir doesn't have to but he doesn't like taking short cuts." Recalling how he crafted the character of Harpeet Singh for *Rocket Singh: Salesman of the Year*, writer Jaideep Sahni says, "He soaked everything Shimit (Amin, the director) threw at him like a sponge and then showed us the guy as he saw him." This despite the only salesman he'd ever seen was the guy

Living with the Lineage

He belongs to Bollywood's first family but doesn't seem to be overawed by that. His take on the greats.



Prithviraj Kapoor

One of the first superstars of Indian cinema. Extremely good looking. He began from scratch and showed us the way. He gave the country a theatre culture.

FAVOURITE PERFORMANCE As the judge in *Awara*



Raj Kapoor

I was six when he passed away. I was the only grandson so he adored me. I once asked him for a suit. He was going to Russia. He came with two bags full.

FAVOURITE PERFORMANCE The simplicity of his character in *Shri 420*. It's my Bible.



Shammi Kapoor

I'm on SMS and BlackBerry with him. It's great to see him living life despite dialysis thrice a week. He took his wife to Paris recently and called Sharmila Tagore from there. He's a *badmash*.



FAVOURITE PERFORMANCE

Teesri Manzil and *Rajkumar*, which my sister and I would do a take off on.



Shashi Kapoor

Great looking man. Everyone in the industry adores him. There's no greed there. No negativity. He became so sad after his wife passed away.



FAVOURITE PERFORMANCE *Jab Jab Phool Khile* and *Deewar*



Rishi Kapoor

My favourite actor. He is what he is. He never fakes it. He feels it. When I was younger, he would create fights with me when he had some intense scene to do. There was no method to his madness, just madness.

FAVOURITE PERFORMANCE *Karz*, *Chandni* and a little known murder mystery called *Khoj*



who delivered the family BMW home. Ranbir, says Prakash Jha, who offered him the complex role of Arjun/Michael Corleone immediately after *Saawariya*, is a "lovely guy, as much at ease with the spotboy as he was with senior actors". A team player, a chronic prankster, a mix of innocence and restlessness are adjectives thrown around about him in a profession

where carping is first nature.

The goodwill may not last for long, and he who has seen the transience of fame affecting his father knows this best. A stellar year like 2009, where he excelled critically in *Wake Up Sid* and *Rocket Singh* and commercially in the wacky *Ajab Prem ki Ghazab Kahani* may well be followed by a year of learning to live with failure. But he